

Instructor Notes: Teaching Digital Safety and Cybersecurity in K-12

The Hackles Kit

Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell.

FIELD COPY

1  <i>Lock It</i> PASSWORDS AND ACCOUNTS	2  <i>Spot It</i> SCAMS AND FAKES	3  <i>Share Smart</i> PRIVACY
4  <i>Safe People</i> WHO TO TRUST	5  <i>Kind and Well</i> KINDNESS AND BALANCE	6  <i>Fix It</i> TELL, REPAIR, RECOVER

PLATE I. The six strands, hand-inked, in the order the lessons take them.

A free kit by **Competence Collective** · competencecollective.org

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For the instructor of the 3-credit course, the 1-credit workshop and the 6-hour PD. Plain advice from the design side: how to pace, how to run sensitive sessions, how to care for the college students in the room, and how to work with a counselor partner. Hackles has not been evaluated or approved by any agency. Nothing here is legal advice.

No student accounts, no student data collected, ever.

01 Before the term (a four-week timeline)

WHEN	DO THIS
4 weeks out	Recruit the counselor partner and agree on Weeks 8 and 9 (Section 6). Confirm field placements and background-check timelines with the field office. Read Module 6 and the Disclosure and Incident Guide yourself, aloud.
3 weeks out	Do each Concepts Lab demo you will teach (Demos 1, 2, 3, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 12, 13, 14) as Part A: Do, Debrief, Teach. Teach what you have felt. Print the practicum card deck and the traffic-light cards.
2 weeks out	Re-verify the [VERIFY] items you will teach (Section 10). Check your state's row in the State Alignment Atlas and read the statute yourself. Collect your institution's language for Title IX and responsible employees, disability services, counseling, academic integrity and AI policy.
1 week out	Load the LMS shell. Post the syllabus. Send a short welcome email with the content note for Weeks 8 and 9, the AI use policy, and the field paperwork list.

Materials per week. Paper, pens, sticky notes, timers, index cards, colored paper for the green-yellow-red lights (Demo 14) and for traffic-light cards (three per person for Weeks 8 and 9). No devices are required for any activity.

02 How the three hours run

EVERY WEEK HAS THE same bones: **opening (10), input and practice, a break (10), more practice, a close (10)**. Predictability helps adults too.

- **Opening ritual.** Say the routine together (Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell.). Read the three group agreements. Remind everyone about the pass card and the open door.
- **Input is short.** Ten minutes of explaining is plenty; then people do something. If you are still talking at minute 25, you are teaching the way the course says not to.
- **Do, Debrief, Teach.** Candidates do the demo, name what surprised them and what a student will ask, then plan the 15-minute version.

- **Time rescue.** If you are behind, cut a round of practice, never the debrief or the close. In Weeks 8 and 9 never cut the de-role.
- **Close.** Exit ticket, open door, one breath. Stay ten minutes afterwards.

Pacing flags by week.

WEEK	LIKELY SQUEEZE	RESCUE
2	Demos 1 and 6 both want 30 minutes	Run Demo 6's Vault Door as a demonstration with volunteers; assign the rest as Part A at home
3	Fake Phish Derby runs long	Use 10 cards instead of 16 (H8 D1 to D10)
6	Mini micro-teach rounds	Use trios and a visible timer; the observer keeps time
7	Four rounds of 20 minutes	Groups of four; start on time; the debrief is whole-class
8	Role-play warm-up	Two rounds, full debrief and de-role
9	Graded practicum for a large class	Run trios in parallel with a second observer (counselor partner, TA); recorded audio for the rest
12	Law and policy overload	Teach the structure of reading a statute; have candidates look up their own state at home
15	Showcase length	Reduce to five-minute segments

03 Adapting for class size, format and level

- **Class of 12 or fewer.** Run activities in pairs and trios. The instructor can observe every micro-teach live.
- **Class of 25 to 40.** Use observer roles heavily. Recruit a TA or a peer coach. Use recorded audio for practicum scoring.
- **Online synchronous.** Use breakout rooms for trios. Provide the cards through the LMS or chat privately to each Teller. Replace traffic-light cards with a reaction, a chat word or a pre-agreed hand signal on camera. Make recording optional, with consent from every participant. Keep the counselor partner in the main room and let them visit breakouts. The written and audio alternatives for the practicum matter even more online.
- **Graduate in-service teachers.** They will bring real stories. Use the same rule as the Facilitator Kit: "skills only, no stories." Offer a private time for anyone who needs to talk, and send everyone to the counselor partner when a situation could involve a child now.
- **Undergraduate pre-service.** Spend less time on policy detail and more on practice and observation. Pair with mentors who have the sensitive-lesson list.

- **Non-education majors (for example, computing or counseling programs).** Pathway C in the Academy (Specialist). Use the Specialist Corner in each module; add Demos 4, 5 and 11 as stations.

04 **Running sensitive sessions (Weeks 8 and 9)**

THESE ARE THE HEART of the course. The same safety rails the Facilitator Kit uses for adults apply here.

Before class.

- Meet the counselor partner. Agree who frames the session, where they will sit or stand, and how they will follow someone who steps out. Give them the cards and the checklist.
- Send the content note to the class a week ahead.
- Have the written alternative ready for anyone who asks. Do not ask why.
- Prepare a quiet room for anyone who needs a break.
- Check your institution's counseling center hours and phone number and put them on the board.

Content note (say it aloud; then post it). "Everything we use today is fictional and non-graphic. The topic can still touch real life, for any of us. You are in charge of your own participation. You may take any role, pass, step out, or choose the written alternative, and nobody will ask why. If you step out, [counselor partner] will check in quietly in a few minutes."

The demonstration. Show first the version we are trying not to do (a shocked, blaming reply), then the calm version. Use a silly low-stakes example (a lost game account). That is the only funny example. Say so.

During practice. Walk the room quietly. Do not eavesdrop. Watch body language. If someone shows yellow or red, move toward them calmly. If a Teller starts to speak in a way that sounds personal, say "Traffic light red" for them and reset.

De-role (never skip). Everyone stands, shakes out hands, says to the trio "I'm [real name]. That was pretend," and takes a slow breath.

Debrief rules. Skills only, no stories. Ask three questions: What is one phrase you plan to keep? What was the hardest thing to avoid saying? Who needs to look at their Contact Card? End with the counselor partner's one-minute care moment.

If it goes sideways.

WHAT HAPPENS	WHAT YOU DO
A candidate becomes visibly distressed	Pause everyone. Offer the quiet room. The counselor partner follows. Resume only if the candidate wants to. Offer the written alternative for the rest of the unit

WHAT HAPPENS	WHAT YOU DO
A candidate discloses a personal experience in the room	Thank them briefly, say "I'd like to talk with you privately, can we do that right after class?" Do not let the group probe. Follow your institution's reporting and support policies. See Section 7
A candidate says something that suggests a child may be in danger right now	Speak with them privately and promptly. Follow your reporting duty and campus policy. The counselor partner helps [VERIFY your policy; COUNSEL TO CONFIRM]
Laughter takes over	Name it kindly: "A lot of us laugh when things feel awkward. That is okay." Do a breath and a reset
Someone uses blame language ("they should have known better")	Respond with the shame-free translation and move on. Do it kindly
A candidate pushes back ("this is too much")	Thank them. Offer choices. This is a normal reaction and a useful practice for handling parent concerns later

Grading the practicum without ruining it. The safety rails say no points, no timers shown and no audience. The graded round therefore happens in trios with an observer checklist and recorded audio (optional) or the written alternative. You do not hover with a stopwatch. Score the checklist behaviors, never emotions. Give feedback privately.

05 Trauma-informed practice for the college students themselves

SOME OF YOUR CANDIDATES will have a personal connection to these topics. You will not know who. Teach as if any of them might be affected, and practice what you ask them to practice.

PRACTICE	IN THIS COURSE
Predictability	Same shape each week. Say what is coming and when. Preview the high-care weeks
Choice	Role options, pass, step out, written alternative, journal prompts they can swap
Safety	Fictional, non-graphic cards. Nobody asked to describe a personal experience or to play a harmed child
Calm closings	De-role, breath, anchoring sentence, instructor stays after
Warmth and respect	No sarcasm. No "just get over it." Thank people for honest difficulty
Collaboration	Ask what would help. Adjust the next session

Language that helps: "You have choices." "Take the time you need." "Many people feel this." "It is okay to pass."

Language that harms: "Just get over it." "You are fine." "Stop being dramatic." "Everyone else can do it."

A note on behavior that looks like misbehavior. Laughing, withdrawing, anger or going quiet may be coping. Respond with calm and curiosity and check in privately.

Do not ask candidates to disclose a history, a disability or a diagnosis. Say that accommodations can be arranged through disability services without telling you why.

If a candidate is a survivor and prefers not to teach sensitive lessons, support that. It is good judgment and does not affect their grade; they can design, observe and teach other lessons.

Instructor self-care. Repeated exposure adds up. Have your own debrief buddy. Ask the counselor partner for a check-in after Weeks 8 and 9.

06 **Working with the counselor partner**

THE KIT CALLS THE role a safety partner. You need one for Weeks 8 and 9 and a standing contact for the rest of the term.

Who. A campus counseling center liaison, a licensed school counselor, or a social worker who knows school reporting routes. They should not be someone who grades the candidates.

What they do.

WHEN	COUNSELOR PARTNER
Before term	Review the practicum cards and the content note. Confirm the campus counseling and crisis numbers. Agree how to follow someone who steps out
Week 8	Co-opens the session; says where they will be; co-demonstrates with the instructor; walks the room; closes with a one-minute care moment; stays after
Week 9	Same, plus sits in on the graded round where needed; leads the "Taking care of you" segment
Week 14	Plays a family member in the Q&A practice for the capstone
All term	Available to candidates; consulted on any concern; helps align field placements with the school counselor

Boundaries. The counselor partner is not a therapist for the class. Their role is framing, safety and referral. Candidates who want counseling are referred through the usual channels.

Reciprocity. Offer the counselor partner a thank-you, a copy of the materials, and an invitation to the showcase. If your program can pay or credit their time, do so.

If you have none. Do not run Weeks 8 and 9 as written. Move the high-care practice to the written and audio alternatives, keep the First 10 Minutes teaching and the Contact Card, and tell the field office that the practicum is a reduced version.

07 If a candidate discloses to you

CANDIDATES MAY WRITE SOMETHING concerning in a journal or say something after class. The same First 10 Minutes ideas apply to adults: calm, thank them, listen, be honest about limits ("I may have duties to share some things; I will tell you what I must do and why"), and refer to campus counseling. **Instructors often have reporting duties** under campus policy for sexual misconduct and, depending on state and role, for child abuse and neglect. Know your policy before the first day and say plainly in the syllabus what a candidate should expect [VERIFY your campus policy and state law; COUNSEL TO CONFIRM]. Do not promise secrecy. Do not investigate. Do not discuss the disclosure with other candidates.

If a journal entry describes a **child currently at risk**, follow your reporting duty and your campus policy at once. Do not wait until grading is done.

08 Assessment logistics

- **Micro-teach (Week 7).** Score from the observer sheet plus a spot-check or recording within one week. Return scores with one glow and one grow.
- **Practicum (Week 9).** Use the 11-item checklist. Keep scoring sheets private. Delete audio at term end. Retakes by Week 11.
- **Unit plan.** A ten-minute conference with each candidate during Week 12 reduces problems with sources and AI use more than any detection tool.
- **Quizzes.** Pull ten items per module from the bank. Re-pull for retakes. Check any item that most candidates miss: it may be unclear. The bank has not been field-tested.
- **Capstone.** Visit one workshop or review a recording with consent. Read the evaluation tally and the limits statement first.
- **Grade conversion.** The rubric to course-score tables are in Assignments and Rubrics.
- **Gate.** Do not let a candidate deliver a supervised lesson before the Response Readiness gate. Document the date.

09 Common problems and kind answers

PROBLEM	WHAT TO DO
A candidate wants to teach a sensitive lesson in field	Not yet. Offer a standard-care lesson and a plan to co-teach under the counselor's lead next year
A candidate reaches for a scary statistic	Ask for the primary source and the denominator. Practice the Number Detective steps. Replace the number with the shape ("real and rising; telling early gives more options")
A candidate says "my lessons will prevent this"	Rewrite the claim: "More students said they would tell a trusted adult." No controlled trial of Hackles exists
A candidate overuses AI	Use the AI use note, process evidence and the conference. Offer a revision. Treat first offenses as teaching moments, and follow your integrity policy for repeats
A candidate worries they "know nothing about tech"	Reassure: the Academy says teaching online safety is mostly teaching skills, not technology. Offer a buddy for Demos 2 and 4
A mentor teacher wants the candidate to teach a higher-care lesson	Decline kindly and explain the gate and the counselor requirement
A student teacher is placed in a school with no counselor	Choose another site or use a district counselor or a college liaison as safety contact

10 What to re-verify every term

THE KIT'S OWN VERIFICATION report lists items it could not confirm. Re-check these before you teach them, and update the LMS pages if they changed:

- The **PPRA** treatment of surveys on protected areas and the reported **Aug 26, 2026** letter from the US Department of Education (kit-verified 2026-10-05; re-verify and ask counsel).
- Your **state's** instruction mandate, mandated-reporter statute and reporting timeline. The Child Welfare Information Gateway summary is current through May 2023.
- **Hotline and website details** (988, Crisis Text Line, NCMEC CyberTipline and Take It Down, FBI pages; the kit could not confirm tips.fbi.gov and 1-800-CALL-FBI).
- **Statistics:** NCMEC, IC3, Thorn, Pew, Common Sense, CDC and UNICEF figures.
- **TAKE IT DOWN Act** platform duties and any FTC guidance updates.
- **Standards:** InTASC and ISTE Educator numbering (unchecked in the kit); CSTA, ISTE Student and CASEL were verified; AI-related standards updates were not checked.
- **Platform facts** (age checks, controls, state actions). Treat as fast-moving and as allegations where noted.

11 Honesty rules for the instructor

- Say plainly that Hackles has not been evaluated in a controlled trial and has not been approved by any state agency.
- Never say the course "certifies" anyone. The Academy certificate is honor-system.
- Mark every legal point [VERIFY] or [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM], and tell candidates why.
- Do not use the kit to sell anything, and do not ask candidates to promote any product.
- Quote only figures you have traced to a primary source.

12 After the term

- Delete recordings and shred paper forms that identify anyone [VERIFY your retention policy].
- Send thank-you notes to mentors, site hosts and the counselor partner.
- Read the course evaluations and your own glow-and-grow notes. Write down what you will change.
- If you want to study the course or share results publicly, use the research toolkit in [kit/28_College/research](#) and get IRB review first.

This document is educational guidance, not legal advice. Consult your institution's counsel and your counselor partner on reporting duties, privacy and safety.